

GovCon BD Upskilling Program

BD Process Fundamentals

Module 3.1 | Domain D3 (22%)

DURATION

2-3 hours

FORMAT

Live Instructor-Led

GovConGiants

30-Day Foundation Program

Module 3.1: BD Process Fundamentals

■ Learning Objectives

By the end of this module, learners will be able to:

1. **Describe** the BD lifecycle and how opportunities move from identification to award
2. **Distinguish** between BD, capture, and proposal phases
3. **Identify** key pipeline stages and gate review criteria
4. **Explain** the role of teaming and why it matters in GovCon
5. **Use** DSBS to identify potential teaming partners

■ Required Reading/Viewing

Official Government Resources (Free)

1. **SBA.gov** - “Teaming and Joint Ventures”
 - URL: <https://www.sba.gov/federal-contracting/contracting-assistance-programs/joint-ventures>
 - Focus: Small business teaming arrangements
2. **DSBS (Dynamic Small Business Search)**
 - URL: <https://dsbs.sba.gov>
 - Focus: Finding small business partners
3. **SAM.gov Entity Search**
 - URL: <https://sam.gov/content/entity-registration>
 - Focus: Verifying contractor registrations

Action Plan Journal References

- **Prime Contractors and You:** pages 88-89
- **Identify Top Ten Prime Contractors:** page 87
- **POC Information for Local Primes:** pages 90-99
- **Register Bidders List for Local Primes:** page 114

Lesson Content

1. The BD Lifecycle: Big Picture

Business Development in GovCon is a structured process that transforms market intelligence into contract awards. Understanding this lifecycle helps everyone in the company contribute effectively.

The Three Phases:

BD Phase	Finding & qualifying opportunities	Ongoing/Long-term	Market research, pipeline building, customer engagement
Capture Phase	Positioning to win a specific opportunity	6-18 months before RFP	Solution development, teaming, customer shaping
Proposal Phase	Responding to solicitation	30-90 days (typical)	Writing, compliance, pricing, submission

Key Insight

Most companies that win do the work in BD and Capture—long before the proposal phase begins.

2. BD Phase: Finding and Qualifying Opportunities

The BD phase is about building a healthy pipeline of qualified opportunities.

Core BD Activities:

Market Research	Understanding agency spending, trends, competitors	Market assessments
Opportunity Identification	Finding relevant solicitations and forecasts	Opportunity log

Qualification	Deciding which opportunities to pursue	Bid/no-bid decisions
Customer Engagement	Building relationships with buyers	Meeting notes, contacts
Pipeline Management	Tracking opportunities through stages	Pipeline reports

Pipeline Stages (Typical):

Identified	Opportunity found via SAM.gov, forecast, or intel	Initial research
Qualified	Passes initial go/no-go criteria	Opportunity assessment
Pursuing	Active BD activities underway	Customer engagement, research
Capture	Dedicated capture effort initiated	Capture plan, solution development
Proposal	RFP released, proposal in progress	Writing, reviews, submission
Submitted	Proposal submitted, awaiting decision	Q&A, orals prep (if applicable)
Won/Lost	Contract awarded or lost	Lessons learned, debrief

3. Capture Phase: Positioning to Win

Capture is the intensive effort to position your company to win a specific, identified opportunity.

When Capture Begins: Typically when an opportunity is qualified and large/strategic enough to warrant dedicated resources.

Core Capture Activities:

Capture Planning	Define win strategy	Capture plan
Customer Engagement	Understand requirements and decision-makers	Call reports, intel
Competitive Analysis	Know your competitors and their strategies	Competitive assessment

Solution Development	Design a winning technical approach	Solution brief
Teaming	Assemble the right team	Teaming agreements
Price-to-Win	Estimate competitive pricing	PTW analysis
Win Theme Development	Craft compelling messages	Win themes, discriminators

The Capture Manager Role

A capture manager is responsible for orchestrating all these activities and leading the team to a winning position before the RFP drops.

4. Proposal Phase: Responding to Win

The proposal phase begins when the solicitation is released and ends at submission.

Typical Proposal Timeline:

Day 1-3	RFP analysis, compliance matrix, kickoff
Day 4-14	Writing, content development
Day 15-21	Reviews (Pink Team, Red Team)
Day 22-28	Revisions, final reviews
Day 29-30	Production, final QC, submission

Note: Timelines vary significantly based on opportunity size and complexity.

Key Proposal Activities:

- **Compliance Matrix:** Mapping RFP requirements to proposal sections
- **Technical Writing:** Describing your solution and approach
- **Past Performance:** Documenting relevant experience
- **Pricing:** Developing competitive and compliant pricing
- **Reviews:** Pink Team (outline/initial), Red Team (near-final)
- **Production:** Formatting, page checks, submission

5. Gate Reviews: Go/No-Go Decisions

Gate reviews are formal decision points where leadership decides whether to continue pursuing an opportunity.

Common Gate Review Points:

Pursue Gate	After identification	Is this worth BD resources?
Capture Gate	Before capture investment	Can we win? Should we invest?
Bid Gate	After RFP release	Final decision to submit

Typical Go/No-Go Criteria:

Capability Match	Direct experience	Adjacent experience	No experience
Customer Relationship	Known buyer	Some contact	No relationship
Competitive Position	Incumbent strong or	Competitive	Longshot
Past Performance	3+ relevant refs	1-2 refs	None
Price Competitiveness	Can win on price	Need to be creative	Can't compete
Resources	Team available	Stretched	Not available
Set-Aside	We qualify	Need partner	Don't qualify

6. Teaming: Why It Matters

Most GovCon opportunities are won by teams, not individual companies. Teaming allows you to:

- **Fill capability gaps** - Bring skills you don't have in-house
- **Meet set-aside requirements** - Partner with qualified small businesses
- **Strengthen past performance** - Leverage partner experience
- **Increase geographic coverage** - Add local presence
- **Reduce risk** - Share workload and responsibility

Teaming Structures:

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Prime/Sub	One company leads, others support	Most common; clear roles
Joint Venture (JV)	New entity formed by two+ companies	Large, long-term opportunities
Mentor-Protégé	SBA program pairing large/small businesses	Structured development relationships
CTA	Multiple primes coordinating	Multiple award IDIQs

Finding Teaming Partners with DSBS:

The **Dynamic Small Business Search (DSBS)** at dsbs.sba.gov helps you find small business partners by:

- Certification type (8(a), HUBZone, WOSB, SDVOSB)
- NAICS code
- Geographic location
- Keywords

Teaming Partner Evaluation Criteria:

Capability	Do they do what we need?
Past Performance	Do they have relevant experience?
Certifications	Do they have needed set-aside status?
Reputation	Are they reliable? Good to work with?
Financial Stability	Can they perform without risk?
Culture Fit	Will they work well with our team?

7. Your Role in BD/Capture

Even if you're not in a formal BD or Capture role, you contribute to the process:

How Non-BD Staff Support Growth:

Program/Project Staff	Identify recompetete opportunities; provide past performance data
Operations	Spot delivery gaps competitors have; suggest improvements

Technical Staff	Contribute to solution development; support proposals
Finance	Support pricing; provide cost data
Contracts	Review teaming agreements; ensure compliance
HR	Support staffing plans; identify key personnel

The "Everyone Sells" Mentality

In the best GovCon companies, every employee understands that growth enables their job security and advancement.

AI Accelerator: Using AI for BD Process Support

AI tools can help you manage pipelines, evaluate teaming partners, and support capture activities.

Prompt 1: Develop Go/No-Go Criteria

Use When: You need to create or refine qualification criteria for your company.

Help me develop go/no-go criteria for a company with these characteristics:

- Size: [SMALL/LARGE BUSINESS]
- Certifications: [YOUR CERTS]
- Core capabilities: [YOUR SERVICES]
- Target agencies: [AGENCIES]
- Typical contract size: [RANGE]
- Current capacity: [AVAILABLE RESOURCES]

Create a scoring matrix with:

1. Must-have criteria (deal breakers if not met)
2. Important criteria (strongly preferred)
3. Nice-to-have criteria (bonus points)
4. Red flags that should trigger no-go
5. Suggested scoring weights for each factor

Prompt 2: Evaluate Teaming Partner Fit

Use When: You've found a potential partner and need to assess fit.

We're evaluating a potential teaming partner for a [AGENCY] opportunity:

Our Company:

- Capabilities: [YOUR SERVICES]
- Certifications: [YOUR CERTS]
- Gap we need to fill: [WHAT WE NEED]

Potential Partner (from DSBS research):

- Name: [COMPANY]
- Capabilities: [THEIR SERVICES]
- Certifications: [THEIR CERTS]
- Size: [SMALL/LARGE]
- Location: [WHERE]

Help me evaluate:

1. Capability complementarity (do they fill our gaps?)
2. Certification value (do they help with set-asides?)
3. Potential conflicts (could they also compete against us?)
4. Questions to ask in initial teaming discussions
5. Red flags to watch for

Prompt 3: Draft Teaming Outreach Message

Use When: You want to reach out to a potential teaming partner.

I want to reach out to [COMPANY NAME] about potential teaming.

Context:

- Opportunity: [BRIEF DESCRIPTION]
- Agency: [AGENCY]
- Why we need a partner: [GAP TO FILL]
- What we bring: [OUR VALUE]
- How we found them: [DSBS, referral, etc.]

Draft a brief, professional outreach email that:

1. Introduces our company concisely
2. Explains why we're reaching out (specific opportunity or general)
3. Highlights potential mutual benefit

4. Requests a brief call to explore fit
5. Sounds professional but not overly formal

Keep it under 150 words.

Pro Tips for AI-Assisted BD

Use AI to draft teaming outreach emails	Send AI-drafted emails without personalization
Get AI help structuring go/no-go criteria	Let AI make final bid decisions
Use AI to summarize pipeline data	Share confidential pipeline data with AI
Draft capture kickoff agendas with AI	Skip human judgment on teaming decisions

Remember

BD is relationship-driven. AI helps with process and analysis, but winning is about people and positioning.

Applied Exercise: Map the BD Process

Scenario: Your company wants to ensure all employees understand how opportunities flow from identification to award. Your manager asks you to create a visual BD process map.

Part 1: Map the Phases

Create a visual representation of the BD lifecycle:

1. Identify the three main phases (BD, Capture, Proposal)
2. List 3-4 key activities under each phase
3. Identify the handoff points between phases

Part 2: Research Teaming Partners

1. Go to DSBS (dsbs.sba.gov)
2. Search for small businesses in a NAICS code relevant to your company

3. Identify 3 potential teaming partners
4. Document their capabilities and certifications

Part 3: Complete the BD Process Map Template

Use the Work Artifact template to document:

- Phase activities
- Gate review criteria
- Potential teaming partners

Time: 45-60 minutes

Work Artifact: BD Process Map

Header

Your Name: _____

Date: _____

Company Context: _____

Section 1: BD Lifecycle Phases

Phase 1: Business Development

Identified			
Qualified			
Pursuing			

Phase 2: Capture

Capture Initiated			
Solution Development			
Pre-Proposal			

Phase 3: Proposal

RFP Analysis			
Writing			
Review/Submit			

Section 2: Gate Review Criteria

Pursue Gate			
Capture Gate			
Bid Gate			

Section 3: Potential Teaming Partners (from DSBS Research)

Company Name	
Certifications	
NAICS Codes	
Capabilities	
Location	
Why a Good Fit	

(Copy for Partners 2 and 3)

Knowledge Check (Self-Assessment)

Question 1 (Recall)

What are the three main phases of the GovCon BD lifecycle?

- A) Marketing, Sales, Delivery
- B) **BD, Capture, Proposal**

- C) Research, Writing, Submission
- D) Planning, Execution, Closeout

Correct Answer: B

Question 2 (Application)

Your company identifies a large opportunity 18 months before the expected RFP release. What phase should you be in?

- A) Proposal phase—start writing now
- B) **BD/Capture phase—engage the customer and develop your solution**
- C) Wait until the RFP is released
- D) Submission phase—prepare your documents

Correct Answer: B

Question 3 (Scenario)

At a Capture Gate review, your team notes: strong capability match, good customer relationship, but the incumbent has held the contract for 10 years and the customer seems satisfied. What should this tell you?

- A) Automatic no-go—incumbents always win
- B) **Proceed with caution—need a strong discriminator strategy to unseat the incumbent**
- C) Full go—customer relationships don't matter
- D) Ignore competitive analysis

Correct Answer: B

Question 4 (Recall)

What tool would you use to find small business teaming partners by certification and NAICS code?

- A) SAM.gov
- B) SAM.gov Contract Data
- C) **DSBS (Dynamic Small Business Search)**
- D) USAspending

Correct Answer: C

Question 5 (Application)

Your company is a large business pursuing a Total Small Business Set-Aside. What's your only path to winning?

- A) Request the set-aside be removed
- B) **Team with a qualified small business who primes, with your company as subcontractor**
- C) Submit anyway and hope they waive the requirement
- D) Large businesses cannot participate in set-asides at all

Correct Answer: B

■ Manager Discussion Prompts

1. **Current Context:** "How does our company manage the BD pipeline? What stages do we use to track opportunities?"
2. **Application:** "Are there opportunities in capture right now where I could contribute? What do you need from my role to support BD efforts?"
3. **Career Development:** "What would help me understand our BD/Capture process better? Are there internal trainings or meetings I could attend?"

■ Completion Criteria

To complete this module:

- ☐ Read all required materials (approximately 20 minutes)
- ☐ Complete the lesson content review (30-45 minutes)
- ☐ Finish the Applied Exercise (process mapping and DSBS research)
- ☐ Submit a BD Process Map with at least 3 teaming partners identified
- ☐ Review the Knowledge Check questions (self-assessment)
- ☐ Participate in manager discussion (or document self-reflection)

Estimated Total Time: 2-3 hours

■ Additional Resources

Free Tools Referenced

DSBS	dsbs.sba.gov	Find small business partners

SAM.gov	sam.gov	Verify registrations, find opportunities
SAM.gov Contract Data	sam.gov/content/contract-data	Research competitor awards

Key Terms

BD (Business Development): Activities to identify, qualify, and pursue opportunities

Capture: Focused effort to position for a specific opportunity

Pipeline: The collection of opportunities being tracked and pursued

Gate Review: Formal go/no-go decision point

Teaming: Partnering with other companies to pursue an opportunity

Prime: The lead contractor holding the government contract

Subcontractor: Company supporting the prime under a subcontract

Joint Venture: New legal entity formed by two or more companies

Action Plan Journal Activities

After completing this module, use your **Action Plan Journal** to:

1. Complete the **Identify Top Ten Prime Contractors** template (page 87)
2. Fill out **POC Information for Local Primes** sheets (pages 90-99)
3. Review **Prime Contractors and You** (pages 88-89) for teaming strategy
4. Use **Register Bidders List for Local Primes** (page 114) to track opportunities

Journal Reference

The BD Process Map you completed connects directly to the Prime Contractor research section in your Action Plan Journal. Teaming partners identified through DSBS should be transferred to your POC sheets.